

sign is in Sinhala, Tamil and English.

The Tamil here, with its lilt, also has an old sensory quality, with words that have perhaps lost currency in Tamil Nadu still finding favour with the public.

In this gorgeous setting, India and Sri Lanka were locked in a first Test that lasted five days, with the rains lending a hand in stretching the contest. In an ICC World Test Championship cycle in which India is placed fifth and Sri Lanka sixth, this game was a crucial outing that could influence the further progress of the rivals. India lived up to its billing as the better unit and won the clash by 165 runs.

Young stars rise

Galle hovers between scalding heat and impromptu showers. This whimsical climate has a bearing on the Test, with a large chunk of the second day lost to the weather. Despite the stop-start nature of the game, India retains its groove, and two young players do the star turn.

Batter Devdutt Padikkal (**in pic**), lucky to play as Sai Sudarshan was ruled out through injury, and left-arm spinner Manav Suthar combined to derail the Sri Lankans. Padikkal's 167 and 44, and Suthar's match haul of 10 wickets, left Dhananjaya de Silva's men stranded for the most part.

Coming in at number three, a slot made famous by his pedigreed Karnataka senior Rahul Dravid, Padikkal was stepping into massive shoes. He looked at ease, and the runs flowed. This is not a southpaw who will make you write poetry, but there is still a certain grace to the way he bats, and a solidity that is essential to turning out at number three.

Suthar, meanwhile, is a throwback to a gentler time. His spin is classical, with flight, drift, dip

and turn, and he is the kind who can choke batters and equally lure them to their doom. The gates were thrown open to the public on all days, and the sparse crowd relished the proceedings.

To the capital

After Galle, it is time to retrace the journey back to Colombo. The road cuts through hills and jungles, and link roads lead towards quaint villages. Open level crossings have signals, and none try to dart across the

rail line when the light is red. The discipline is pleasing to watch and offers a sobering contrast to what vehicle users do in India.

In the capital, a city eulogised in *Colombo, Port of Call* by Ajay Kamalakaran, there is an air of the old, especially the Victoria Memorial building, and the frisson of the present, thanks to the skyscrapers.

There is more history to be savoured at the Tamil Union Club at the P. Sara Oval, where Don Bradman once played. The next day, in a friendly match, the India scribes lose to their Sri Lankan counterparts, and one local writer wryly quips: "So the series is 1-1, guess the second Test at SSC is the tie-breaker."

